

ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

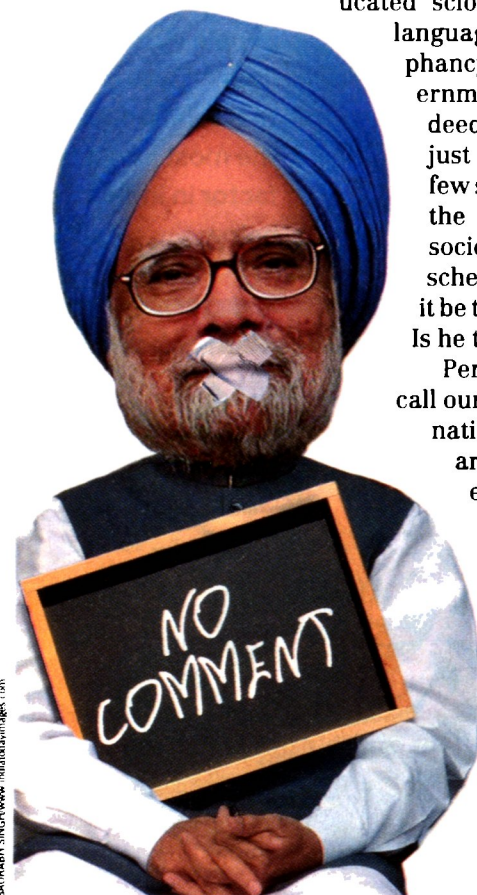
Mister Mum

The prime minister is lucky that we have such low expectations. Both of politicians and of ourselves. As he droned through an incredibly tedious press conference, disallowing supplementary questions, waffling on specifics and stonewalling controversies, we were getting what we deserve. Our socialist hangover means we are so used to shortages that the fact the prime minister was being asked questions by the national media for only the fourth time in six years (apart from two joint press conferences with Sonia Gandhi) was itself ground for wall-to-wall celebration on news channels. Given that Singh thinks India is a country of a billion dollars, he should consider how Barack Obama, despite having had at least 10 press conferences in the last year, is accused of being remote. One of the kinder nicknames for him is President Spock.

In contrast, what do we have? A triumvirate happiest when it's thumbing its nose at the national media, never mind all the open letters soliciting one-on-one interviews and the soft focus chats immediately after the Women's Reservation Bill. Sonia Gandhi has fielded questions from the collective media only thrice on her own and twice with the prime minister. Rahul Gandhi has done collective Q & A eight times, only one of them in Delhi. The good don't speak up and the bad hog the headlines. Is it any wonder we are so cynical about our young, flag-waving politicians endorsing khap panchayats and other young Western educated scions speaking the

language of psychopancy? Should a government interested in doing not communicate its deed to its citizens? Is the government's message just a slogan that does not stand the scrutiny of a few supplementaries? It shows a deep distaste for the media that no amount of co-option of civil society in advisory councils and cleverly drafted schemes for the social sector can overcome. Could it be that the prime minister doesn't know enough? Is he the professor who doesn't know it all?

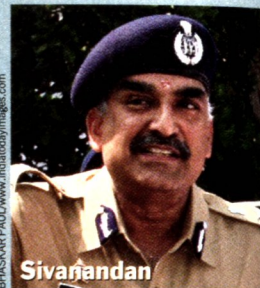
Perhaps it's also time for us to change what we call our politicians. Leaders are expected to share a nation's emotion. Rage with us when CRPF jawans are killed for no fault of theirs, when tax payers' money meant for rural jobs and urban housing ends up in the pockets of middlemen and when corruption is allowed to gush like a BP oil spill. Leaders are supposed to protect us from big business, not resolve their family disputes; enable young people to live better lives, not let them be killed in the pursuit of love and liberty; usher us into the third decade of liberalisation, not just pat themselves on the back for its first 20 years. What we have are just unprofessional politicians.



SARABJI SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Mumbai Commissioner of Police **D. Sivanandan**, 59, as Maharashtra's director-general of police. A 1976-batch IPS officer, he takes over from A.N. Roy.



BHASKAR PAUL/www.indiatodayimages.com

DIED: Malayalam writer **V.V. Ayyappan** aka Kovilan, 87, who authored 11 books and 12 collections of short stories. He had worked in the Royal Indian Navy from 1943 to 1946 and in the Corps of Signals from 1948 to 1968.

APPOINTED: Kuldeep Singh Bhardwaj as the ambassador to Algeria. He is currently a joint secretary. Ranjit Rae, ambassador to Budapest, has been named as the envoy to Vietnam.

WON: By pugilist **M.C. Mary Kom**, her third Asian title when she won the gold at the Asian Championship at Astana, Kazakhstan. L. Sarita Devi won a gold and her fourth Asian title.



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